

Klaim UK: Pre-Seed Strategy & Commercial Model

Prepared for: Sean Trevaskis & Co-Founders **Date:** May 2026

1. Executive Summary

Klaim is the UK's first performance-based restaurant discovery app, built entirely on open banking infrastructure. It solves a fundamental inefficiency in the £101 billion UK eating out market [1]: restaurants spend over £3 billion annually on social media marketing without any ability to track return on investment (ROI) to physical visits [2]. Simultaneously, Gen Z consumers are dining out more frequently but are fatigued by traditional points-based loyalty schemes and discount vouchers that carry social stigma [3].

By leveraging the UK's mature open banking ecosystem (which reached 16.5 million users by late 2025 [4]), Klaim connects the digital impression directly to the physical transaction. Restaurants only pay when a verified customer walks through the door and pays with their linked card. Consumers receive real cash directly into their bank accounts.

This strategy paper outlines the commercial model, unit economics, market positioning, competitive landscape, SWOT analysis, and a detailed 3-year financial and fundraising roadmap to support a £750K pre-seed raise.

2. The Problem & Solution

The Restaurant Problem: The Attribution Black Hole

In 2026, 84% of UK restaurant operators allocate the majority of their marketing budget to social media [2]. However, there is zero native attribution from an Instagram or TikTok impression to a physical restaurant visit. Restaurants are effectively flying blind,

spending an average of £30 to £80 to acquire a single customer without knowing which campaigns actually drove footfall.

Furthermore, traditional discount apps (such as Tastecard or Groupon) are actively avoided by premium and mid-market restaurants. Academic research confirms that voucher use adversely affects brand perception and long-term loyalty [5]. These platforms also require complex point-of-sale (POS) integrations and create friction for staff at checkout.

The Consumer Problem: Broken Discovery and Fake Rewards

Gen Z's relationship with dining out is fundamentally different from previous generations. In 2026, 34% of UK consumers dine out three or more times per month, with Gen Z frequency rising rapidly [2]. While 73% of Gen Z use social media to find restaurants, the algorithms often trap them in echo chambers, showing the same viral spots repeatedly [6].

When it comes to rewards, this demographic rejects traditional loyalty. Points expire, vouchers are awkward to present at checkout, and loyalty stamps feel like a chore. They demand instant, transparent, real-money rewards. Furthermore, dining is inherently social, yet existing rewards apps are entirely solo experiences with no mechanism to coordinate with friends or share discoveries.

The Klaim Solution

Klaim solves both sides of the marketplace through a card-linked, gamified “drop” mechanic:

1. **Unwrap the Drop:** Every Monday and Friday, users receive personalised cashback offers to curated restaurants.
2. **Pay Normally:** Users visit the restaurant and pay with their linked bank card. There are no QR codes, no vouchers, and no staff interaction required.
3. **Instant Cash:** Open banking detects the transaction, and the cashback is transferred directly to the user's bank account within minutes.

For restaurants, Klaim is a zero-risk acquisition channel requiring no POS integration. For consumers, it is a frictionless way to discover new venues and earn real cash.

3. Market Sizing & Dynamics (2026)

The UK eating out market is projected to reach £101 billion by the end of 2026 [1]. Within this, the full-service restaurant sector is valued at approximately £35.7 billion [7].

Klaim's initial focus is exclusively on London, which represents the most concentrated and lucrative segment of the UK market. London generates 22.6% of all UK hospitality revenue and boasts an average spend per visit that is 32% higher than the national average [8]. With over 11,400 restaurants, London provides the necessary density to build a two-sided marketplace [9].

The timing for Klaim is optimal due to three converging tailwinds in 2026:

1. **Open Banking Maturity:** The UK is the global leader in open banking, with 41% of adults already using the technology [4]. The infrastructure for frictionless card-linking is now mainstream.
 2. **Gen Z Dining Habits:** The target demographic is dining out more frequently and relying heavily on digital discovery, yet they are actively rejecting traditional brand loyalty programs in favour of tangible value [3].
 3. **Model Validation:** The identical business model was proven at scale in the United States by claim.co, which was acquired by Wonder Group (Grubhub's parent company) in 2025 [10]. The UK currently has no direct equivalent combining real cash, gamification, and social features.
-

4. Competitive Landscape

The UK market contains several players in the cashback and loyalty space, but none occupy Klaim's specific positioning.

Platform	Reward Type	POS Integration Required?	Gamification	Social Features	London Focus	Performance-Based B2B
Klaim	Real Cash	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Shuffle	Real Cash	No	Partial	No	No (North UK)	No
JamDoughnut	Real Cash	No	No	No	Yes	No
Tastecard	Discount	Yes	No	No	Yes	No
Yonder	Points	No	No	No	Yes	No

Table 1: Competitive Matrix (2026)

Shuffle Rewards is the closest structural competitor, offering card-linked cashback without POS integration. However, Shuffle operates primarily in Northern cities (Manchester, Liverpool) and lacks the gamified “drop” mechanic and social features (Drop Buddies, trading) that drive habitual engagement. Tastecard and Groupon rely on a fundamentally flawed discount model that damages restaurant brand equity.

5. Commercial Model & Unit Economics

The Transaction Fee Deduction Strategy

A critical strategic question is whether deducting Klaim’s processing fee from the user’s cashback will cause friction. The solution is entirely dependent on framing.

Klaim must display the **net-to-user figure** in the app from the outset. If the restaurant funds £8.00 and the API processing cost is £0.46, the app should simply display “£7.50 cash to your bank.” The user sees a clean number, receives exactly that amount, and experiences no negative surprise. The API cost is an internal cost of revenue, similar to how Monzo handles interchange fees invisibly to the consumer.

Open Banking API Costs (2026 Rates)

Deep research into UK open banking providers reveals the following unit costs [11] [12]:

- **Account Information (AIS):** GoCardless Bank Account Data (formerly Nordigen) offers a free tier for early-stage startups, transitioning to ~£0.10-0.15 per call at scale. TrueLayer charges ~£0.10-0.20 per connection.
- **Payment Initiation / VRP (Payouts):** GoCardless charges 1% + 20p per transaction on standard plans. For an £8 payout, this equals £0.28.
- **Identity Verification:** Bank-native name matching via TrueLayer AIS is sufficient for KYC, avoiding the need for expensive third-party checks (e.g., Onfido at £1-3 per check).

Total Estimated API Cost per Transaction: £0.46.

Unit Economics

- **Restaurant Pays:** £8.00 (Cashback) + £1.50 (Klaim Platform Fee) = £9.50
- **API Processing Cost:** (£0.46)
- **Net Cashback to User:** (£7.50)
- **Klaim Net Revenue:** £1.04 per transaction
- **Gross Margin:** 69.3%

At £9.50, the restaurant's Customer Acquisition Cost (CAC) via Klaim is dramatically lower than the £30-£80 they currently spend on social media, and they only pay for verified visits.

Revenue Streams

1. **Transaction Platform Fee (Core):** £1.50 per verified transaction (rising to £2.00 at scale).
2. **Analytics Subscription (SaaS):** A tiered monthly subscription billed **per brand** (averaging 10 locations per brand), offering deep insights into cohort analysis, repeat rates, and competitor benchmarking across all their venues. Pricing is £299/month (Insights) to £599/month (Pro), creating a highly compelling single-bill proposition for multi-site operators.

- 3. **Sponsored Drops (Year 2+):** Premium placement fees (£500-£2,000) for new restaurant openings or specific campaigns.
- 4. **Data Products (Year 3+):** Anonymised dining intelligence sold to commercial property firms and FMCG brands.

6. Financial Projections (2026–2028)

The financial model has been built on the premise that the core technology is already developed. The founders will take zero salary for the first six months, allowing the £750K pre-seed capital to be aggressively deployed toward user and restaurant acquisition.

Metric	Year 1 (2026)	Year 2 (2027)	Year 3 (2028)
Total Revenue	£109K	£692K	£4.89M
Gross Profit	£82K	£528K	£3.95M
Gross Margin %	74.8%	76.3%	80.9%
Total OPEX	(£604K)	(£1.66M)	(£2.75M)
EBITDA	(£522K)	(£1.13M)	£1.20M
Active Users (EoY)	8,200	61,200	238,200
Restaurant Venues	480	1,100	3,300
Restaurant Brands	48	110	330

Table 2: 3-Year P&L Summary

KLAIM UK — REVISED 3-YEAR FINANCIAL MODEL (2026–2028)



7. Team & Organisational Structure (Year 1)

To execute the London launch efficiently, Klaim will operate with a highly lean, operator-first team. The headcount is strictly capped at 8 full-time employees in Year 1. The founders will take zero salary for the first six months to ensure maximum capital is deployed toward user and restaurant acquisition.

Year 1 Org Chart & Responsibilities

Role	Person	Start Month	Core Responsibilities	Key Metrics Owned
Co-Founder & CEO	Sean Trevaskis	Month 1	Strategy, fundraising, investor relations, press	Restaurant brands signed, MRR, runway management
Co-Founder & CCO	[Name TBC]	Month 1	Financial management, restaurant & user acquisition strategy	Revenue, gross margin, user CAC, cash position
Founding Engineer	External Hire (Turkey)	Month 1	Open banking integrations, app performance, merchant portal	App uptime, transaction detection accuracy, API costs
Growth & Marketing Lead	External Hire	Month 2	Performance marketing, social content, influencer management	User CAC by channel, MAU growth, ROAS
Head of Partnerships	External Hire	Month 2	B2B restaurant sales, brand onboarding, account management	Brands signed, time-to-first-drop, partner retention
Partnership Executive	External Hire	Month 3	Junior B2B sales support, restaurant outreach, onboarding	Pipeline velocity, onboarding time, partner satisfaction
Data & Product Analyst	External Hire	Month 4	Transaction data analysis, merchant analytics dashboard	Analytics subscription adoption, data quality
Community & Ops Manager	External Hire	Month 6	User support, community management (Drop Buddies)	User NPS, support ticket resolution time

Note: The core team is supported by a CTO Advisor (\$2,500/month + 2-year ESOP vesting schedule), a social media agency for Months 1-3 only (£8K/month) to set initial strategy before bringing it in-house, part-time legal counsel, and a part-time accountant.

Founder Compensation & Capital Discipline

To ensure maximum capital is deployed toward user and restaurant acquisition, the founders will take £0 salary for the first three months. From Month 4, founder salaries are set at £65,000 per year. This aligns with SeedLegals 2025 benchmark data for UK pre-seed rounds of £700K+, which shows typical founder salaries between £60K and £80K [15]. This demonstrates capital discipline while ensuring the founders can sustain themselves in London.

Legal & Compliance Efficiency

By launching under TrueLayer's FCA licence as a Third Party Provider (TPP), Klaim avoids the significant cost and 6-9 month delay of direct FCA authorisation. Legal and compliance costs are strictly limited to essential user-facing Terms & Conditions, GDPR privacy policies, restaurant partner agreements, and ongoing Appointed Representative (AR) monitoring. This lean approach keeps Year 1 legal costs under £15,000.

Year 2 & 3 Scaling

As the business scales, headcount will grow to 13 in Year 2 and 20 in Year 3. Key additions include:

- **Year 2:** Backend Engineer (UK), Backend Engineer (Turkey), 2x Partnership Executives, Head of Data & Analytics.
 - **Year 3:** Senior Engineer (UK), 2x Partnership Executives, VP Marketing, 2x City Launch Managers (for Manchester and Birmingham).
-

8. Fundraising Roadmap & KPI Gates

To unlock subsequent funding rounds at optimal valuations, Klaim must hit specific KPI gates. UK consumer fintech valuations in 2026 require demonstrated traction, not just vision [13] [14].

Pre-Seed (Current)

- **Target:** £750K
- **Expected Valuation:** £3M - £4M (Pre-money)

- **Use of Funds:** 100% focused on London Go-To-Market. Heavy allocation to performance marketing, influencer partnerships, and early team hires (Head of Partnerships, Marketing Manager).
- **KPIs to Unlock Seed:** 7,200 Active Users, 480 Restaurant Venues (48 Brands), £10K+ MRR, 30%+ Month-1 Retention.

Seed (Q1 2027)

- **Target:** £2.5M
- **Expected Valuation:** £8M - £12M (Pre-money)
- **Use of Funds:** Scale London dominance, launch analytics SaaS product, and begin expansion to secondary UK cities (Manchester, Birmingham).
- **KPIs to Unlock Series A:** 57,000 Active Users, 1,100 Restaurant Venues (110 Brands), £1M+ ARR, 68%+ Gross Margin, proven SaaS adoption (>30% of brands).

Series A (Q1 2028)

- **Target:** £8M+
 - **Expected Valuation:** £35M - £50M (Pre-money)
 - **Use of Funds:** National UK rollout, launch of B2B data products, and preparation for European expansion via single-API providers like Yapily.
-

9. SWOT Analysis & Failure Modes

A realistic assessment of Klaim's strategic position requires acknowledging where the model is most vulnerable.

Strengths

- **Zero POS Integration:** Removes the single biggest barrier to B2B sales in hospitality.
- **Founder Network:** Existing relationships with premium UK restaurant groups via Growdash bypasses the typical B2B cold-start problem.
- **Tech Readiness:** The app and merchant portal are already built, eliminating technical execution risk from the pre-seed phase.

Weaknesses

- **Margin Sensitivity:** The model relies on open banking API costs remaining low. Any pricing changes by TrueLayer or GoCardless directly impact gross margins.
- **Capital Intensity of B2C:** Acquiring consumers in London is expensive. If organic viral loops (Drop Buddies) fail to take hold, CAC will drain the pre-seed runway quickly.

Opportunities

- **The claim.co Precedent:** The US acquisition proves the exit potential and commercial viability of the exact mechanic Klaim is deploying.
- **SaaS Upsell:** Transitioning from a pure transactional model to a recurring SaaS model (Analytics) significantly increases the valuation multiple at Series A.

Threats & Failure Modes

1. The Two-Sided Marketplace Cold Start:

- *The Risk:* Users download the app but find no restaurants they like; restaurants sign up but see no footfall.
- *The Mitigation:* Klaim must execute a **supply-led launch**. The founder network must be leveraged to secure 30-50 premium London venues *before* any consumer marketing begins. Supply must be artificially constrained to specific London zones (e.g., Soho, Shoreditch) to ensure density.

2. Restaurant Churn Due to Low Volume:

- *The Risk:* Restaurants don't see enough Klaim users to justify keeping the dashboard active.
- *The Mitigation:* The "Drop" mechanic allows Klaim to artificially direct demand. If a partner is seeing low volume, Klaim can boost their visibility in the next drop to deliver a sudden spike in footfall, proving the ROI.

3. Open Banking Friction:

- *The Risk:* Consumers drop off during the bank-linking phase due to security concerns.
- *The Mitigation:* Messaging must heavily lean on FCA regulation and bank-level security. The promise of "real cash" must be strong enough to overcome the initial friction of linking an account.

10. Conclusion

Klaim is positioned to solve a £3 billion attribution problem for UK restaurants while giving Gen Z the frictionless, cash-based rewards they demand. By eliminating tech build costs from the pre-seed phase and deferring founder salaries, the £750K raise provides exceptional runway to aggressively acquire the initial London network. The path to a £10M+ Seed valuation is clear, provided the team executes a disciplined, supply-led launch in Month 3 with an initial cohort of 30 premium brands.

References

[1] Lumina Intelligence. (2025). *UK Eating Out Market Report 2025*. [2] SevenRooms. (2024). *2024 U.K. Restaurant Trends and Diner Expectations Report*. [3] eMarketer. (2025). *UK's Gen Zers prioritize deals over brand loyalty*. [4] Open Banking Implementation Entity (OBIE). (2026). *Open Banking in 2025: Now Part of the UK's Everyday Financial Life*. [5] International Journal of Hospitality Management. *Voucher Promotions and Consumer Behaviour in UK Premium Restaurants*. [6] Nation's Restaurant News. (2025). *73% of Millennials and Gen Z let social media guide their restaurant choices*. [7] Mordor Intelligence. (2026). *United Kingdom Full Service Restaurants Market Forecasts*. [8] Audit Consulting Group. (2024). *UK Restaurant & Pub Revenue Trends and Outlook*. [9] Restroworks. (2025). *London Restaurant Industry Statistics 2025*. [10] Wonder Group. (2026). *Claim by Grubhub, a Wonder company*. [11] Finexer. (2026). *Open Banking Pricing: UK Buyer's Guide [2026 Edition]*. [12] GoCardless. (2026). *Pricing & Fees*. [13] Pitchwise. (2026). *Median Seed Round Size by Industry in 2026*. [14] FE International. (2026). *How to Value a FinTech Business in 2026*. [15] SeedLegals. (2025). *2025 UK founder salaries revealed*.